In some ways, since its foundation in 2010 the MaBaTha has become more influential than the older 969 Movement. They now have a great deal of control over religious education in Myanmar,[84] which they use to teach their extremist anti-Muslim interpretation of Buddhism. They have also been running a number of campaigns to force Buddhists to boycott Muslim-owned businesses.[85] More critically, they have been at the forefront of every instance of violence against Myanmar's Muslim communities. In particular, the violence in Rakhine in 2012 and 2013 was orchestrated by an alliance of the RNDP and the MaBaTha.[86]

Recent evidence suggests a simple reason for the MaBaTha's influence: it seems to have been set up by the military as a front organisation.[87] Not only do the generals probably believe their own rhetoric that the Rohingyas have no place in Myanmar, but civil unrest is potentially very useful for them.[88] Having badly lost the 2015 elections, they may find it far easier to justify a coup on the grounds of major domestic unrest rather than one overthrowing a democratic government. In the meantime the MaBaTha have another useful role. The USDP struggles to appeal to many Burmese apart from those directly employed by the state.[89] In the same way that the 969 Movement allowed the NLD to broaden its electoral appeal, in 2015 the MaBaTha campaigned for the USDP.

In effect, the military is directly backing two different groups in contemporary Myanmar. It has, in the USDP, a notionally non-sectarian political organisation (and, to be fair, until the 2015 election campaign, one of its MPs was an ethnic Rohingya) with a guaranteed block of parliamentary seats. And it now has its own organisation of Buddhist extremists who both offer the means to channel electoral support to the USDP and to create violence that can later be used to justify a military intervention. It is against this background that many Western observers persist in believing that Myanmar is making a steady, if occasionally rocky, transition to democracy.[90]

Civil society

Although less important than the organised political parties and groups of Buddhist monks, Myanmar also has a small civil society movement. Networks such as Pan Zagar[91] deliberately challenge the incendiary